

V9 Cultivating Empathy

Absorbs C16 (Empathy in Communication). Empathy mapping exercise retained from C16; workplace application framework retained from the original V9.

Pillar	Vulnerability	Difficulty	Level 1
Time Required	40-50 minutes	Group Size	4-12
Mode	Team facilitation	Format	In-person or remote
Prerequisites	None	CLOVER ERA Trigger	Low empathy indicators, interpersonal friction, team members feeling unheard or misunderstood, silos between sub-groups

Why This Works

THE NEUROSCIENCE

Empathy engages the brain's mirror neuron system, a network that fires both when we perform an action and when we observe someone else performing it. When we actively try to understand another person's experience, we are not just thinking about them; our brain is simulating their state. This simulation triggers oxytocin, deepening social bonds and reducing the 'us vs. them' patterns that cortisol-driven stress creates.

Cognitive empathy (understanding someone's perspective) and emotional empathy (feeling what they feel) use different neural circuits. Most workplace training focuses on cognitive empathy because it feels safer. But emotional empathy, in appropriate doses, is what actually builds trust. The empathy mapping exercise in this worksheet activates both circuits by asking people to consider what a colleague is thinking AND feeling.

The Exercise

Phase 1: The Three Types (5 minutes)

Briefly introduce three types of empathy. Keep this tight, under 3 minutes of talking:

- Cognitive empathy: understanding someone's perspective ("I can see why you'd think that")
- Emotional empathy: feeling what they feel ("That sounds really frustrating")
- Compassionate empathy: being moved to help ("What can I do to support you?")

WHAT TO SAY

"We all use these differently. Some of us are good at understanding perspectives but less comfortable with the emotional side. Some of us feel others' emotions strongly but struggle to put that understanding into action. None of these is wrong. The goal is to broaden our range."

Phase 2: Empathy Mapping (15 minutes)

Retained from C16. This is the strongest exercise in the collection for building empathy skills.

WHAT TO SAY

"Think about one colleague you interact with regularly who you find it difficult to understand or connect with. Not someone you dislike. Someone you find yourself puzzled by, or someone whose reactions you don't always predict. Don't name them."

"Now map out four things: What might they be feeling in their current work situation? What might they be thinking about the challenges they face? What are they seeing around them (pressures, expectations, team dynamics)? What are they hearing from others (feedback, criticism, support, silence)?"

Give 8-10 minutes for individual mapping. Provide a simple 2x2 grid template (Feeling/Thinking/Seeing/Hearing) on paper or Miro.

FACILITATION NOTE

Do NOT ask people to share who they mapped. They can share insights from the process without revealing the person. The question is: "What did you notice when you tried to step into their perspective?" not "Who did you map?"

Phase 3: The Empathy Barrier Inventory (10 minutes)

WHAT TO SAY

"What gets in the way of empathy at work? Not in theory. For us, on this team. What are the real barriers?"

Collect on flipchart/Miro. Common barriers: time pressure ("I don't have time to think about what they're feeling"), assumptions ("I already know why they do that"), task focus ("We're here to get work done, not process emotions"), self-protection ("If I empathise, I'll take on their stress").

For each barrier, ask: "What's one small thing we could do differently to reduce this barrier?" The answers should be specific and doable, not aspirational.

Phase 4: One Commitment (5 minutes)

WHAT TO SAY

"Before we close, I want each person to identify one empathy commitment for the next two weeks. Something specific. Not 'be more empathetic.' Something like 'Before I respond to that colleague's

next email, I'm going to re-read it imagining I'm in their position first."

Go round the room. Each person states their commitment briefly. The public statement creates a lightweight accountability mechanism.

Facilitation Notes

Situation	Response
The empathy mapping feels artificial or uncomfortable	Normalise it: "This is a practice exercise, like a gym workout for your perspective-taking muscles. It feels odd at first. The value shows up when you're in a real conversation and you automatically consider the other person's position before reacting."
Someone uses the exercise to complain about a specific colleague	Redirect: "This exercise is about understanding, not diagnosing. Let's stay with what they might be experiencing rather than what they're doing wrong." If a real interpersonal issue surfaces, address it separately outside the exercise.
The team identifies time pressure as the primary empathy barrier and feels helpless about it	Reframe: "Empathy doesn't require extra time. It requires a different moment of attention. Pausing for 5 seconds before responding to consider the other person's state is not a time investment. It's a quality investment."

Signs This Is Working

Timeframe	What to Look For
During the session	Empathy maps produce genuine reflection ("I never thought about what they might be hearing from the other team") Barrier discussion generates honest self-assessment Commitments are specific and personal, not generic
Within 1-2 weeks	A team member pauses before reacting in a tense moment (visible effort to consider the other perspective) Someone asks a perspective-taking question in a meeting: "How is this landing for you?" Interpersonal friction between specific pairs decreases
CLOVER ERA data (2-4 weeks)	Vulnerability scores improve (empathy and vulnerability are tightly linked) Communication scores improve (empathic listening is a communication skill) Qualitative data references being heard, understood, or supported

Cross-Pillar Connections

Worksheet	Connection	Direction
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V1: Vulnerability Circle	Empathy is the receiving side of vulnerability. V9 teaches the skill of receiving what V1 asks people to share.	Complementary (can run in either order)
V11: Workload Struggles	Empathy is essential for workload conversations. Without it, workload discussions become complaints rather than collaborative problem-solving.	Run V9 before V11
C9: Conflict Communication	Empathy is the foundation of constructive conflict. C9 conflict skills depend on V9 empathy skills.	Run V9 before C9